

Plugins

Introduced: v1.0.33 (April 2025) | Latest enhancements: v2.1.51

What It Is

Plugins are distributable bundles that package skills, agents, hooks, MCP servers, and LSP configs into a single installable unit. A plugin is a directory with a `.claude-plugin/plugin.json` manifest. You can install plugins from marketplaces, load them from local directories, or create your own. Plugin skills are namespaced (`/plugin-name:skill-name`) to prevent conflicts.

Why It Matters

Without plugins, you'd manually copy skills, hooks, and MCP configs between projects. Plugins let you: – Share your team's coding standards as an installable package – Install community tools (linters, formatters, language servers) in one step – Bundle MCP servers with their configuration – Version and distribute your automation

Quick Start (60 Seconds)

Create a minimal plugin

```
mkdir -p my-plugin/.claude-plugin
cat > my-plugin/.claude-plugin/plugin.json << 'EOF'
{
  "name": "my-plugin",
  "description": "My first Claude Code plugin",
  "version": "1.0.0"
}
EOF
```

Add a skill

```
mkdir -p my-plugin/skills/hello
cat > my-plugin/skills/hello/SKILL.md << 'EOF'
---
description: Say hello
---
Greet the user warmly.
EOF
```

Test it

```
claude --plugin-dir ./my-plugin
```

```
# Inside Claude Code
/my-plugin:hello
```

Plugin Directory Structure

```
my-plugin/
├── .claude-plugin/
│   └── plugin.json          # Manifest (required)
├── skills/                  # Skills (optional)
│   └── code-review/
│       └── SKILL.md
├── agents/                  # Custom subagents (optional)
│   └── security-reviewer.md
├── hooks/                   # Event hooks (optional)
│   └── hooks.json
├── .mcp.json                # MCP server configs (optional)
├── .lsp.json                # LSP server configs (optional)
├── settings.json            # Default settings (optional)
├── commands/                # Legacy commands (optional)
├── README.md
└── LICENSE
```

Important: Only `plugin.json` goes inside `.claude-plugin/`. Everything else is at the plugin root.

Configuration

plugin.json (Manifest)

```
{
  "name": "my-plugin",
  "description": "What this plugin does",
  "version": "1.0.0",
  "author": {
    "name": "Your Name",
    "email": "you@example.com"
  },
  "homepage": "https://github.com/user/plugin",
  "repository": "https://github.com/user/plugin",
  "license": "MIT"
}
```

CLI Flags

Load plugin locally (development)

```
claude --plugin-dir ./my-plugin
```

Load multiple plugins

```
claude --plugin-dir ./plugin-one --plugin-dir ./plugin-two
```

Interactive Commands

/plugin install <name>	# Install from marketplace
/plugin uninstall <name>	# Remove plugin
/plugin list	# List installed
/plugin enable <name>	# Enable
/plugin disable <name>	# Disable
/plugin update [name]	# Update

Enable/Disable in settings.json

```
{
  "enabledPlugins": {
    "swift-lsp@claude-plugins-official": true,
    "my-local-plugin": true,
    "inactive-plugin": false
  }
}
```

Format: plugin-name@marketplace or just plugin-name for local plugins.

Marketplace Configuration

Add custom marketplaces:

```
{
  "extraKnownMarketplaces": [
    "https://github.com/myorg/plugin-marketplace/raw/main/plugins.json"
  ]
}
```

Marketplace JSON format:

```
{
  "owner": { "name": "Your Team" },
  "plugins": [
    {
      "name": "team-standards",
      "source": "https://github.com/team/standards-plugin",
      "description": "Team coding standards and review tools",
      "tags": ["code-review", "standards"]
    }
  ]
}
```

```
]
}
```

What You Can Bundle

Skills

skills/code-review/SKILL.md

Invoked as /my-plugin:code-review (namespaced).

Custom Agents

agents/security-reviewer.md

Frontmatter: name, description, model, permissions, tools, hooks.

Hooks (hooks/hooks.json)

```
{
  "hooks": {
    "PostToolUse": [
      {
        "matcher": "Write|Edit",
        "hooks": [{ "type": "command", "command": "npm run lint:fix" }]
      }
    ]
  }
}
```

MCP Servers (.mcp.json)

```
{
  "plugin-api": {
    "type": "stdio",
    "command": "${CLAUDE_PLUGIN_ROOT}/bin/server",
    "args": ["--config", "${CLAUDE_PLUGIN_ROOT}/config.json"]
  }
}
```

Use \${CLAUDE_PLUGIN_ROOT} for plugin-relative paths.

LSP Servers (.lsp.json)

```
{
  "go": {
    "command": "gopls",
    "args": ["serve"],
  }
}
```

```

    "extensionToLanguage": { ".go": "go" }
  }
}

```

Real-World Workflows

Workflow 1: Team Standards Plugin

```

mkdir -p team-standards/.claude-plugin
cat > team-standards/.claude-plugin/plugin.json << 'EOF'
{"name": "team-standards", "description": "Engineering standards", "version": "1.0
EOF

mkdir -p team-standards/skills/review
cat > team-standards/skills/review/SKILL.md << 'EOF'
---
name: review
description: Review code against team standards
allowed-tools: Read, Grep
---
Check code against our standards:
- Functions < 20 lines
- No console.log in production code
- All async functions have error handling
- API responses use our standard format
EOF

# Everyone on the team installs
claude --plugin-dir ./team-standards

```

Workflow 2: Full-Stack Plugin with MCP + Hooks

```

fullstack-plugin/
├── .claude-plugin/plugin.json
├── .mcp.json                # Database connection
├── hooks/hooks.json         # Auto-format on save
├── skills/
│   ├── migrate/SKILL.md    # Database migrations
│   └── deploy/SKILL.md     # Deployment steps
└── agents/
    └── db-reviewer.md      # Database query reviewer

```

Workflow 3: Publish to Marketplace

```

# 1. Create plugin repo
gh repo create my-plugin --public

```

```
# 2. Push plugin code
cd my-plugin && git init && git add . && git commit -m "Initial" && git push

# 3. Add to marketplace
# Edit marketplace plugins.json to include your plugin URL

# 4. Team installs
claude
> /plugin install my-plugin
```

How It Interacts With Other Features

Feature	Interaction
Skills	Plugin skills are namespaced: /plugin:skill
Hooks	Plugins define hooks in hooks/hooks.json
MCP	Plugins can bundle MCP servers (auto-start on enable)
Agent Teams	Teammates inherit enabled plugins from lead
Remote Control	Plugins active in remote sessions (run locally)
Worktrees	Plugins discovered in worktree directories
Settings	Plugin settings.json applies when enabled (currently: agent key only)

Gotchas & Tips

1. **Skill namespacing** – plugin skills use /plugin-name:skill-name, not just /skill-name. The plugin name must match the manifest name field.
2. **\${CLAUDE_PLUGIN_ROOT}** – use this for all paths in MCP configs, hooks, and agents. Absolute paths break when others install your plugin.
3. **Plugin settings are limited** – only the agent key is supported in plugin settings.json currently.
4. **Git timeout** – plugin installation clones from git. Increase timeout with CLAUDE_CODE_PLUGIN_GIT_TIMEOUT_MS=120000 (default: 30s → now 120s in v2.1.51).
5. **Don't nest** – put skills, hooks, agents at the plugin root, NOT inside .claude-plugin/.

6. **Version pinning** – marketplaces can pin specific versions for stability (v2.1.51+).
-

Version History

Version	Date	Change
v1.0.33	Apr 2025	Plugin system introduced, marketplace integration
v2.0.x	Late 2025	Plugin hooks and agent support
v2.1.0	Jan 2026	Plugin skills with SKILL.md frontmatter
v2.1.45	Feb 2026	enabledPlugins and extraKnownMarketplaces from CLI
v2.1.45	Feb 2026	Plugin agent skills loading by bare name
v2.1.51	Feb 2026	Custom npm registries, version pinning, git timeout 120s
v2.1.51	Feb 2026	Plugin settings.json for default configuration